3.3 War in the West and East

You may have heard the phrase "divide and conquer" from a parent or coach. Union military leaders used the same strategy to try to defeat the South.

MAIN IDEA The Union attacked strategic areas in the western and eastern parts of the Confederacy in the early years of the Civil War.

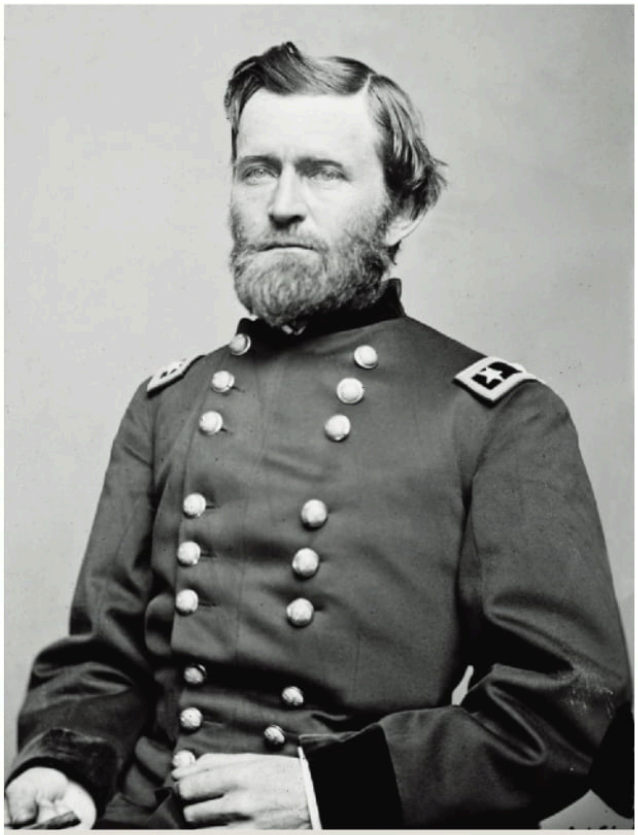
THE BATTLE OF SHILOH

In 1862, Union and Confederate forces clashed in important battles in the western part of the Confederacy. The region had some of the Confederacy's most important assets, including New Orleans, its largest city, and many major ports along the Mississippi River. The North set its sights on capturing the region.

To that end, two Union generals, **Ulysses S. Grant** and **William T. Sherman**, sailed troops on a fleet of 19 riverboats up the Tennessee River. Seven of the vessels were **gunboats**, small, fast ships carrying mounted guns. The fleet successfully captured two key forts in Tennessee, Fort Henry and Fort Donelson, forcing the Confederate Army to retreat. On February 25, the Union Army continued its march across Tennessee with the goal of reaching Corinth, Mississippi—a major rail center—where 20,000 more Union soldiers awaited them. If Grant captured the railroads at Corinth, the Union would control most of the western part of the Confederacy.

However, General Albert Sidney Johnston, the Confederate commander in the region, learned of Grant's plan and ambushed the Union general's forces near a church in Shiloh, Tennessee, on April 6. The larger Confederate forces drove Grant's troops back. By the next day, however, more Union forces had arrived, and Grant led a counterattack. The Confederates conceded defeat and withdrew to Corinth.

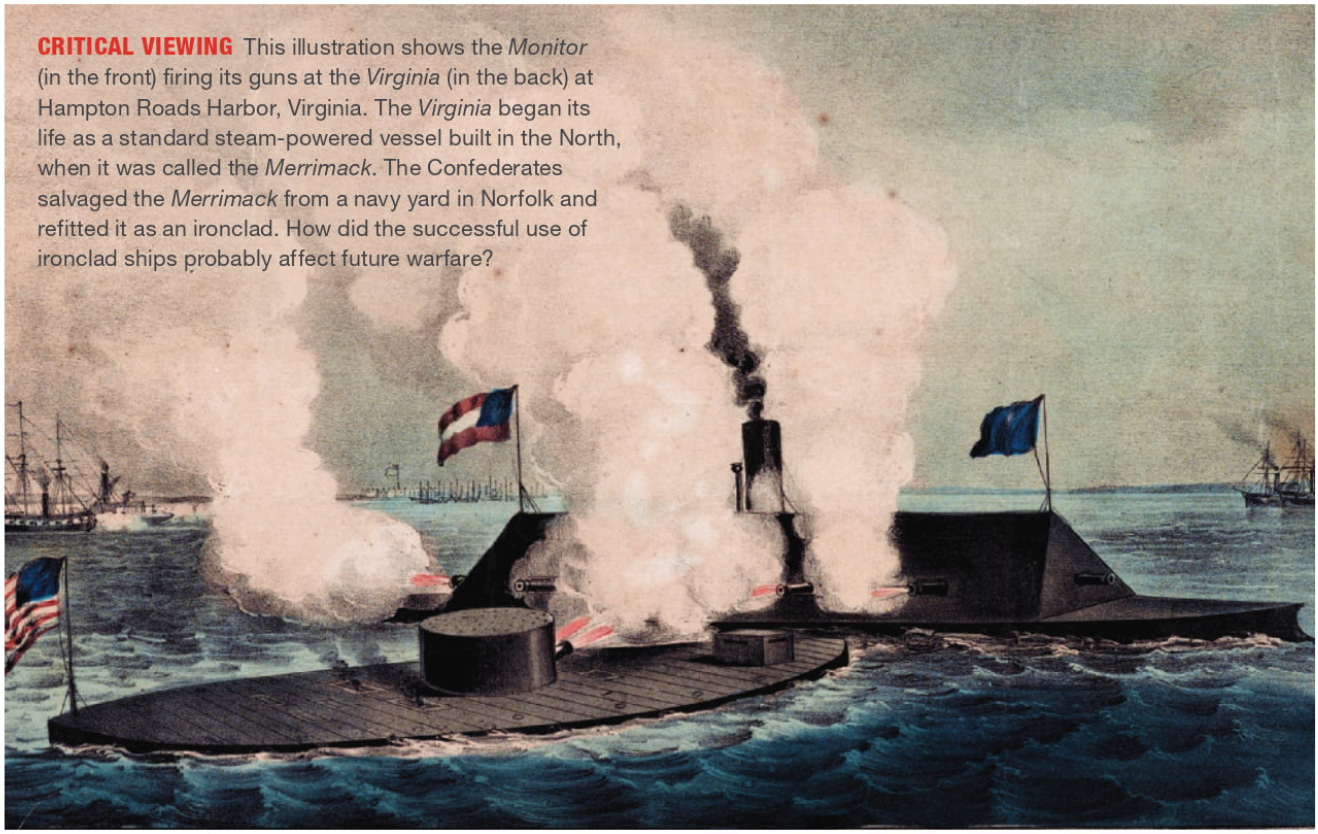
The two-day **Battle of Shiloh** was the bloodiest battle in the war to that point. The South lost more than 10,000 men, including General Johnston. Even though it won the battle, the Union Army actually lost more men: about 13,000 soldiers. Because of the high casualty count, some people called for Grant's removal, but Lincoln refused. He is said to have remarked, "I can't spare this man [Grant]; he fights!"



Ulysses S. Grant

After graduating from West Point, Ulysses S. Grant served with General Winfield Scott during the Mexican-American War, as had his Confederate opponent, Robert E. Lee. After the Civil War, Grant became president of the United States in 1868, when he was only 46 years old. His presidency was plagued by scandal, although Grant himself was an honest man.

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CRITICAL VIEWING This illustration shows the *Monitor* (in the front) firing its guns at the *Virginia* (in the back) at Hampton Roads Harbor, Virginia. The *Virginia* began its life as a standard steam-powered vessel built in the North, when it was called the *Merrimack*. The Confederates salvaged the *Merrimack* from a navy yard in Norfolk and refitted it as an ironclad. How did the successful use of ironclad ships probably affect future warfare?

THE SEVEN DAYS' BATTLES

Meanwhile, the Union had undertaken another campaign in the eastern part of the Confederacy with the goal of capturing the Confederate capital of Richmond, Virginia. On March 9, 1862, the Confederate ironclad ship, the C.S.S. *Virginia*—also known as the *Merrimack*—faced off against the Union ironclad, the U.S.S. *Monitor*. It marked the first skirmish between ironclad warships. The battle took place in the harbor of Hampton Roads, Virginia, and ended in a standoff.

Lincoln urged General George B. McClellan to continue the advance toward Richmond. McClellan had replaced Winfield Scott as the leader of the Union Army and was a brilliant general. But McClellan's tendency to overestimate the enemy's strength and postpone troop movement often frustrated Lincoln. McClellan eventually set sail with about 120,000 troops to the coast of the Virginia Peninsula. The Union forces battled their way to within a few miles of Richmond. But, fearing that he might be outnumbered, McClellan pulled his men back.

On June 1, rebel forces led by the new commander of the Confederate Army, Robert E. Lee, took advantage of McClellan's caution and moved to protect Richmond. From June 25 to July 1, Lee and his forces went on the attack and fought an offensive war, called the **Seven Days' Battles**. Lee forced McClellan to retreat back down the Virginia Peninsula, but even as they were being pursued, the Union forces still managed to inflict heavy casualties on the Confederates.

Nonetheless, the victory of the Seven Days' Battles boosted southern morale, saved the Confederate capital, and made Lee a hero. But as Lee's star was rising, McClellan's was falling. McClellan's failures made Lincoln's opinion of him sink even lower.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What did the Union Army hope to accomplish in the western part of the Confederacy in 1862?
2. **SUMMARIZE** Describe the Union advance toward Richmond.
3. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** How did the Seven Days' Battles affect the combatants and the leaders of the war?

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